

TEACHER LESSON PLAN

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Music, Stories & Movement

PreK–K · Homeroom / General

THE 25 MINUTES

5 min	8 min	10 min	2 min
HOOK	BIG IDEA	ACTIVITY	CLOSING

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

What children will understand

Children will discover that people can express their feelings and tell their stories through music, art, and movement. Through sound and guided imaginative play, they will be introduced to the idea that a group of Black artists and musicians in Harlem, New York, made something beautiful together a long time ago — and that their music still makes us want to move today.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

- **CCSS.ELA-LITERACY SL.K.1 / SL.K.4** — Participate in collaborative conversations; describe familiar people, places, things, and events
- **NCSS Standard I (Culture)** — Explore similarities and differences in ways groups meet human needs; music and art as cultural expression
- **National Arts MU:Re7.1 (PreK)** — With guidance, identify and describe how a specific music selection makes them feel
- **Head Start Early Learning Outcomes** — Creative Arts Expression: child explores and expresses ideas through music, movement, and visual arts

MATERIALS NEEDED

- Device to play 60 seconds of jazz — Louis Armstrong's "What a Wonderful World" or Cab Calloway's "Minnie the Moocher" work beautifully
- Optional: scarves or ribbons for movement activity (one per child)
- Differentiated handouts (Green / Yellow / Red) — one per child, printed before class
- Large crayons or thick markers

HOOK · 5 MINUTES

Can you feel the music?

Play the music clip. Let children respond however they want — nodding, swaying, smiling.

"This music was made a long, long time ago — before your parents were born, before your grandparents were born! A group of really special musicians lived in a place called Harlem in New York City, and they made music that was so joyful and so new that the whole world stopped to listen."

"When you heard that music, what did you feel in your body?"

Take responses — there are no wrong answers. Then stand up together and move to 30 more seconds of music.

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · 8 MINUTES

A big move and a big idea

Sit children in a circle or on the carpet.

"A long time ago, many families moved from one part of America to another — a very long journey, like if you packed all your favorite things in a suitcase and moved to a whole new place. When they arrived in Harlem, something magical happened: musicians, storytellers, and painters all found each other and started making beautiful things together. We call that the Harlem Renaissance — that means 'Harlem Reborn'."

"They made music. They made paintings. They made poems. They made stories. All to say: we are here, and we are wonderful."

Show two or three images if available — a Harlem street scene, a jazz band, or Aaron Douglas artwork.

ACTIVITY · 10 MINUTES

Making something beautiful

Distribute handouts. Play gentle jazz quietly in the background while children work.

GREEN LEVEL
MORE SUPPORT

Children draw how the music makes them feel using colors and shapes. A single sentence frame (*"The music makes me feel ___"*) with a very large drawing box. Designed for pre-writers — drawing IS the response.

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

Children draw a picture of what they would make if they lived in Harlem — music, a painting, a dance, a story — and write or dictate one sentence about it.

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Children draw two things: what Harlem music looked like to them, and something they would contribute. They complete a simple sentence about why they would make it. A full writing line for children ready to write independently.

Note: All three levels use the same large type and large drawing boxes — differentiation is in task complexity, not presentation.

Circulate and talk to children about what they're drawing. With 2 minutes remaining, invite two or three children to share.

CLOSING · 2 MINUTES

We made something too

"Just like the people in Harlem made music and paintings to share how they felt — today you made something too! You drew your feelings, your ideas. That's what artists do. The Harlem Renaissance was made by people just like you, who had something beautiful inside them and decided to share it."

TEACHER NOTES

- **Pacing:** With younger PreK children, cut the direct instruction to 5 minutes and extend the movement to 2 minutes. The music itself does the work at this age.
- **For ESL/ELL students:** The music is completely language-independent. Pair with images. Accept drawing as a full response — sentence frames are scaffolds, not requirements.
- **Follow-up:** Display children's drawings as a class "Harlem Gallery" before or after the Mini Museum visit.

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the exhibition: If the Harlem Renaissance exhibition is available at your school, bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more firsthand. Ask your librarian to arrange a visit.

Option 2 — Virtual visit: Explore the full exhibition online.

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance